



Domenico di Michelino's painting *The Comedy Illuminating Florence*, depicts Dante, the city of Florence, and scenes from the *Divine Comedy*.

ALTHOUGH THE GHIBELLINES HAD BEEN EXPELLED FROM FLORENCE (see 1286–90), factionalism still plagued the city, with a drawn-out **power struggle** between the old aristocratic nobility, the new mercantile nobles, and the powerful guilds. The **Guelph** faction split into Black (extreme) and White (moderate) parties. In 1301, the Whites expelled the Blacks, only for them to return when **Charles, count of Valois**, entered the city. The following year the Black Guelphs sentenced the Whites to death or exile—among them the poet **Dante Alighieri** (see panel, right).

In 1301, **Pope Boniface VIII** (c. 1235–1303) supposedly issued a bull asserting **papal supremacy** over France. In fact, the bull was a forgery, put out by the French king **Philip IV the Fair** (r. 1285–1314) to stir up animosity against the pope. Philip “responded” by calling one of the first **Estates General**—

including representatives of the towns and clergy—and received their backing. Boniface **excommunicated** Philip and Philip called for the Pope to face **criminal charges**. In 1303, agents acting for Philip forced their way into the papal apartments in Anagni and **arrested the Pope**, who died soon after. Facing tumultuous conditions in Italy, in 1303 the cardinals elected the archbishop of Bordeaux as **Pope Clement V**. Although hoping to establish himself in Italy when the violence subsided, Clement remained in southern France, finally settling in **Avignon** in 1309, then owned by the king of Naples. This temporary arrangement for the papacy would last until 1378.

Palais des Papes

Situated on a rocky outcrop, the papal palace in Avignon is one of the largest and most important medieval Gothic buildings in Europe.



“LET EVIL SWIFTLY BEFALL THOSE WHO HAVE WRONGLY CONDEMNED US—GOD WILL AVENGE US.”

Jacques de Molay, the Grand Master of the Knights Templar, cursing King Philip and Pope Clement V, 1314



The torture of Jacques de Molay, Grand Master of the Knights Templar.

FROM THEIR HUMBLE BEGINNINGS, WHEN THEY HAD BEEN SO POOR that two knights sometimes had to share a horse, the **Knights Templar** had risen to dizzying heights. With the backing of Cistercian abbot **Bernard of Clairvaux** (1090–1153), and subsequently the Pope, they had won exemption from secular jurisdiction and taxation, and thrived as donations of land and money poured in. By the 13th century they had become **de facto bankers** to much of Europe, able to direct a large fleet and maintain the primary **Crusader army** in Outremer. Templar knights rose to prominence all over Europe, especially in England, where the **Master of the Temple** was the first baron of the realm. In the early 13th century, then **Master William Marshal** ruled the country as regent for the young king **Henry III** (1207–72). However, after the **fall of Outremer**, the Templars were struggling to stay afloat, and presented an easy target for their enemy, **Philip IV of France**. Philip coveted the Templar lands and cooked up charges of **heresy** in which to indict them. On October 13, 1307, Philip’s officials simultaneously **arrested every Templar in France**. They were accused of a **variety of crimes**, including sexual and occult outrages and worshipping an idol. The **use of torture** obtained lurid confessions, and over the next few



Hereford Mappa Mundi

The world is shown as a disk, with Jerusalem at the center. Trade and pilgrimage routes are illustrated, together with places of interest.

years around **60 Templars were executed**. Elsewhere in Europe, some arrests were made, but there was much less appetite for condemning the order. At the **Council of Vienne** (1311–12), Philip forced Pope Clement to **dissolve the Templars**, and in 1314 the last Grand Master, Jacques de Molay, was burned at the stake.

Hereford, in England, was an important center for the **wool trade**—one of the main sources of wealth in medieval England. Foreign buyers flocked to the country to buy wool for export to the **textile industries** of Flanders and Italy, and the wool trade was described as “**the jewel in the realm**.” The wealth of places such as Hereford was expressed in the magnificence of their

cathedrals and the richness of their accessories. At Hereford Cathedral a huge **Mappa Mundi** (map of the world) was created in around 1300 (its creation is variously dated to 1285 and 1314) and used as an altarpiece; it is the largest mappa mundi in existence. Such maps encapsulated the medieval world view on the eve of the **Age of Discovery**.

At the Battle of Bannockburn in 1314, **Robert the Bruce**, king of Scotland (r. 1306–29), finally expelled the English from Scotland.



DANTE ALIGHIERI
(1265–1321)

Dante is the greatest Italian poet to have lived and one of the most important writers in European literature. He is best known for his epic poem the *Divine Comedy*, and for his tragic love for Beatrice, who married another and died young. Exiled from his native Florence for political reasons, Dante spent much of his life traveling from one city to another. He died in Ravenna in 1321.

